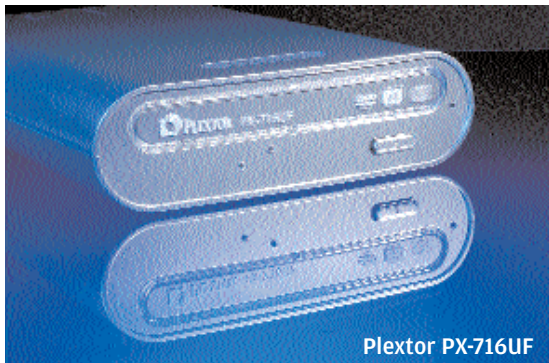




Plextor PX-716UF

Performance

Read speeds and access times

We carried out the Nero CD-DVD Speed Test on DVDs as well as CDs to gauge read speeds, access times, CPU usage, etc. for the drives. In the DVD read test, we found the Lite-On the fastest, with the Sony not much slower. The Plextor could not complete the transfer rate test despite multiple attempts.

In the CD read test, the Lite-On was the top performer. The SiSoft Sandra test reflected similar results, and we can conclude that the Lite-On is a better drive for when you need to read data—as in when you install software, restore backed-up data, or watch movies off the drive.

Ripping

In the audio CD ripping test as well as in the DVD video ripping test, all the drives performed well except the Plextor. Something—we don't know what—crippled this drive's performance, causing it to take almost twice the time, in both the tests, that the others did.

Writing

In the CD-R writing test, the BenQ was the slowest, and the Lite-On was the fastest. In the DVD-R writing test, the Plextor and Lite-On were neck-and-neck, with just a couple of seconds separating them. The picture was a bit different in the DVD+R

writing test: the BenQ drive supported over-speed burning! It could effortlessly burn 8x DVD+R media at 12x, thus taking about 25 per cent less time per DVD—to do so as compared to the other drives. This is significant in, say, offices, where many DVDs are burnt every day.

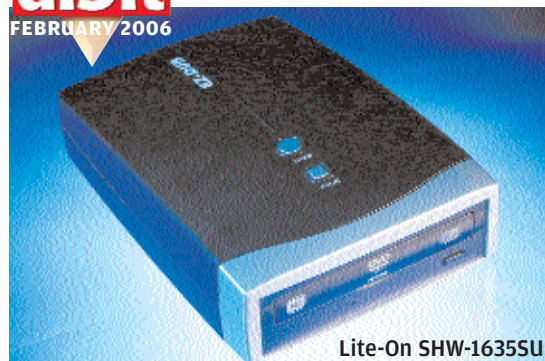
The Plextor produced mixed results in this test. Whereas it scored second-best in the sequential data write, it came in last in the assorted data write test. For backup purposes, therefore, the Lite-On is better if the media is CD-R, and the BenQ is undoubtedly better for DVD+R.

In the DVD-RW writing test, the BenQ once again proved its mettle by being able to over-speed burn the media. It burnt data at 2.4x for the 2x DVD-RW, while the others drives could only burn at the rated 2x.

In Conclusion

So who's the winner? We need to take the prices into consideration to figure that out. The prices ranged from the Rs 6,495 for the Lite-On to the astronomical Rs 11,250 for the Plextor.

The Lite-On DVD-Writer returned good performance as well as a good feature set, which included EZ-DUB. And it carries the lowest price tag. We've therefore adjudged the Lite-On SHW-1635SU the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold in the external DVD-Writers category.



Lite-On SHW-1635SU

A Parting Word

In this shootout, we tested and compared a large range of DVD-Writers that are available in the Indian market.

Those of you who read our last review of DVD-Writers—carried in our November 2004 issue—might have noticed that there was a great degree of variation in the performance and prices of the drives that were reviewed back then. This time, it's a completely different picture...

The technical limits of DVD-Writing have been reached, like we mentioned earlier, and almost all the drives had comparable features and maximum read and write speeds.

The only new technology we've seen this time round is LightScribe, and even this is a niche technology. Drives that feature it are priced considerably higher. With the unavailability of LightScribe compatible media in India, it remains to be seen how well LightScribe DVD-Writers will take off here.

The same can be said for DVD-RAM drives and media. Despite boasting of a 9.5 GB capacity, and having been around for quite a long time, it's still hasn't been able to garner enough support from drive manufacturers—owing to the considerably high price tag of the media.

One technological advancement in writers has been the introduction of the SATA interface, but, as of yet, no such devices are available in the Indian markets.

When we test optical storage devices the next time round, we probably will not be testing only DVD-Writers, because Blu-ray and HD-DVD-Writers will soon make forays into PC hardware markets worldwide.

Pioneer launched the first Blu-ray drive—the BDR-101A—for the PC in late December 2005, thus becoming the first new format to hit the markets after DVD. HD-DVD will surely follow soon.

Though this may sound repetitive, buying CD-Writers just doesn't seem to make sense today, considering the falling prices of DVD-Writers. If you buy an optical drive, make sure it's a DVD-Burner! ■

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Contact Sheet – DVD Writers

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Asus	ASUSTek Computer Inc.	022-40058894	info_india@asus.com.tw	www.asus.com.tw
Benq	BenQ India Pvt Ltd	022-25705230	salesinquiryin@benq.com	www.benq.com
Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology (India) Ltd	022-26526696	sales@gigabyte.in	www.gigabyte.in
LG	LG Electronics India Ltd	9899302074	avarshney@lgezbuy.com	www.lgezbuy.com
Lite-On	Mediatech India Distribution Pvt Ltd	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.liteonit.com.tw
Plextor	Prime ABGB Pvt Ltd	022-23896600	primeservices@vsnl.com	www.plextor.com
Samsung	Samsung India Electronics Ltd	011-41411234	vikas.tagra@samsung.com	www.samsungindia.com
Sony	Rashi Peripherals Pvt Ltd	022-28221013	navinderc@rptechindia.com	www.sony.com